

Falling Tetrominoes: A case study of Cold War Diplomacy and Trade between the USSR and the
United States through *Tetris*

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Tetris was the first Soviet computer software to cross the Iron Curtain and reach global renown. Since the conception of its idea in the Soviet Union Computer Academy, it took multiple stages of licensing for the game to finally be seen on consoles and family computers, available to the public in the Western world. The frantic grab for a share of *Tetris* eventually culminated in Moscow, where businessmen from the UK and the United States negotiated directly with branches of the USSR government. The birth and popularization of *Tetris* revealed the shifts in diplomatic relations during Reagan's administration, attempts to establish global trade amid Cold War conflicts, and how the two nations handle new ideas and innovation differently. The technological and economic tensions between the Soviet Union and the Western world, led by the United States, were obstacles that manifested through the export of *Tetris*. The commercial success of the game utilized the United States' advantage in monetizing and protecting innovations, eventually becoming a global gaming phenomenon.

Pajitov created *Tetris* while working at the Russian Academy of Sciences in 1984¹, but was mostly left out of the negotiations themselves. The game achieved widespread success within the academy, but the concept of commercialization was unheard of as a next step to monetize the fame, since the Academy and the state owned all intellectual property. Nevertheless, Pajitov's manager sought to take the game beyond the borders of the Soviet Union, sending it to Hungary and displaying it at the SZKI Institute in Budapest². In this case, Hungary acted as an intermediary for the Eastern Bloc, allowing the game to be exposed to Western Europeans who visited and, by extension, the "free" world. Due to the difficulty of communication across the Iron Curtain, the original creator, Pajitov, did not participate in most of the negotiations. It was first Robert Stein, a British businessman, who recognized the potential

¹ Tetris, "The History of Tetris," Tetris Official Website, accessed April 2, 2026, <https://tetris.com/news/the-history-of-tetris>.

² Dan Ackerman, *The Tetris Effect : the Game That Hypnotized the World* (PublicAffaiSoftwarers, 2016), 90.

of Tetris and sought to acquire its license from Pajitov himself, from whom he received a vague answer positive enough to start his production. The rights were also shared with Stein's sister company in the United States, Spectrum Holobyte, which was the first to publish the game in the United States³. Different licenses to publish Tetris on arcades, computers, and consoles were distributed to several firms before the Soviet Union took notice of this. Due to the difference in technological progress, the contract that was initially signed by the Soviet Union did not fully define the difference between gaming consoles and personal computers. After much debating, Henk Rogers, who initially bought the license for personal computers from Spectrum Holobyte, was sent by Nintendo America to settle the dispute directly in Moscow. He finally moved the Soviet ELORG officials managing import and export of software, and acquired the rights for handheld consoles, yet another rising force in the gaming industry, for Nintendo, which amounted to the immense success of both the game and the platform it was published on, the Game Boy.

Around the same year when *Tetris* was developed, the Reagan administration published multiple speeches in 1983 denouncing the Soviet Union, most famously calling it an “evil empire”⁴ that lacks democratic representation and religious morality. Previously, the *detente* in the 1970s saw a period of increasing trade between the two sides of the Iron Curtain, which also gave rise to technological and scientific cooperation, like the Apollo-Soyuz mission. However, the diplomatic relationships between the two superpowers quickly worsened when the Soviet Union invaded Afghanistan, compelling President Jimmy Carter to revive containment. Specifically, the Carter Doctrine defined any military action in the Persian Gulf as an “assault on

³ Ackerman, *The Tetris*, 105.

⁴ "'Evil Empire Speech' by President Reagan - Address to the National Association of Evangelicals," video, YouTube, posted by Ronald Reagan Presidential Foundation & Institute, April 3, 2009, <https://youtu.be/FcSm-KAEFFA?si=uK7B-l8lKv9lKyPN>.

the vital interests” of the United States, justifying renewed tensions between the United States and the Soviet Union.⁵ The Soviet Union relied heavily on technology imports from the United States; this supply line of modern technology was cut off along with grain. Despite the various conflicts happening in proxy regions, the threat of mutual destruction under nuclear arms compelled both sides to find ways to avoid direct military confrontation and, in President Reagan’s words, “find peace through strength.”⁶ During this period, multiple negotiations initiated by the United States showed an outward desire for peace, only to be interrupted by the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan in 1979 and the declaration of martial law in Poland in 1981⁷. The vast ideological difference seems irreconcilable between the two nations.

Events took a turn in 1985, when Gorbachev came to power as the general secretary of the Communist Party. Under Gorbachev, known for his attempts at de-Stalinization, the Soviet Union saw a turn toward more transparent and democratic policies, with *Perestroika*, meaning “restructuring,” as their collective name. Soviet economic policies at the start of the 1970s revealed a general shift toward economic deregulation and catching up with global development. Previously, the superior military position of the Soviet Union concealed the reality of economic stagnancy. A strong centralized control of technology and science paid off successfully, bringing the Soviet Union to the central stage of the Cold War on par with the United States. Gorbachev emphasized the importance of the people being the “masters of production,” decentralizing commercial activity to generate an “inner stimuli.”⁸ Not only did he champion open and free trade within the Soviet Union, but he also emphasized the importance of reestablishing

⁵ "138. Address by President Carter on the State of the Union before a Joint Session of Congress," in *Foundations of Foreign Policy*, ed. Kristin L. Ahlberg, vol. I, *Foreign Relations of the United States, 1977–1980* (Washington: United States Government Printing Office, 2014), digital file.

⁶ "Evil Empire," video.

⁷ "U.S.-Soviet Relations, 1981–1991," Office of the Historian, accessed May 11, 2026, <https://history.state.gov/milestones/1981-1988/u.s.-soviet-relations>.

⁸ Mikhail Sergeevich Gorbachev, *Perestroika : New Thinking for Our Country and the World* (Perennial Library, 1988), 71, digital file.

commercial ties with foreign countries. He recognized that capitalism was unlikely to dissolve on its own, and global commerce is the only way to perform “economic turnaround and [close] the technological gap” between the Soviet Union and the Western countries⁹. With economics at the forefront of the USSR’s domestic and foreign policy, Gorbachev questions the possibility of self-sustainment and considers trading technology with Western countries, even attempting to export Soviet technology. Gorbachev’s attitudes indicated that he was a “reasonable” partner to negotiate with, and Reagan met with him multiple times within the next several years to negotiate peace and arms reduction treaties.¹⁰

On the other side of the world were the widely controversial economic policies of President Reagan, aiding nascent firms to grow and expand. The Reagan administration took over an economy suffering from a sharp increase in the inflation rate and the consumer price index.¹¹ In an attempt to restore the vitality of the market system, the 1980s saw the return of economic conservatism, most notably the Economic Recovery Tax Cut of 1981 in terms of fiscal policy. As the name suggests, Reagan expects the reduced tax rates to encourage corporate growth with higher revenue and wages, stimulating. The tax cut disproportionately benefited people in the higher tax brackets, creating larger income disparities. As a result of his tax cuts, government budgets fell into a steady deficit, and so did general welfare. Reagan promoted employment opportunities and higher wages instead of a social security system, advertising self-realization through a freer market economy as inherently American. However, despite an initial peak in 1982, the unemployment rate drastically decreased during Reagan’s administration

⁹ Roderic Lyne, "Making Waves: Gorbachev's Public Diplomacy, 1985-86," *Proceedings of the Academy of Political Science* 36, no. 4 (1987), <https://doi.org/10.2307/1173846>.

¹⁰ "U.S.-Soviet Relations," Office of the Historian armswere.

¹¹ Olivier Jean Blanchard et al., "Reaganomics," *Economic Policy* 2, no. 5 (1987): 17, <https://doi.org/10.2307/1344620>.

from 10.8%, the highest in December 1982, to 5.2% in 1989¹². Real median household income also increased by nearly 10,000 dollars from 1982 to 1988¹³. Reagan's economic policies did have their intended effect of stimulating the market, but it was riskier than expected and came at the expense of income equality. In this environment, businesses, especially those in the newer sectors, had an easier time starting up with less tax burden. This feature also attracted international firms like Nintendo, one of the leading video game companies with an established reputation in Japan, to establish the Nintendo of America office in 1980¹⁴.

The development of *Tetris* highlighted the significant gap in technological progress between the USSR and the United States, especially in emerging fields such as computer science. The first version of *Tetris* was programmed on the Soviet Elektronika 60M, a loose copy of the American PDP-11/23 computer that was released in the 1970s, where Pajitov had to use text symbols like brackets and periods to draw out the playing field due to the technical restraints of the Elektronika. In the same year, both Apple and IBM released their personal computer, the Macintosh and the PC/AT, respectively, in the United States¹⁵. While the Elektronika had a RAM (Random Access Memory, a quantity that indicates the computation power) size of 4 KB¹⁶, the PC/AT and the Macintosh had 512KB¹⁷ and 256 KB¹⁸ RAM, much larger than the Elektronika 60M. The computational power of a computer at a Soviet institution could not compare with that of an average household computer in the United States. It did not take long for Pajitov and

¹² U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, "Unemployment Rate [UNRATE]," Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/UNRATE>.

¹³ U.S. Census Bureau, "Real Median Family Income in the United States [MEFAINUSA672N]," Federal Reserve Bank of St. Louis, <https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/MEFAINUSA672N>.

¹⁴ Ackerman, *The Tetris*, 169.

¹⁵ "1984 / Timeline of Computer History," Computer History Museum, <https://www.computerhistory.org/timeline/1984/>.

¹⁶ "MC 1260 'Elektronika 60M,'" Soviet Digital Electronics Museum, Sergei Frolov, last modified October 29, 2008, http://www.leningrad.su/museum/show_calc.php?n=257

¹⁷ IBM PC/AT Technical Reference, "Bitsavers.org, http://bitsavers.informatik.uni-stuttgart.de/pdf/ibm/pc/at/1502494_PC_AT_Technical_Reference_Mar84.pdf.

¹⁸ "Macintosh Classic: Technical Specifications," Apple Support, <https://support.apple.com/en-us/112195>.

another computer genius, Vadim Gerasimov, to adapt the software for the more popular IBM PC, but national technological gaps could not be eliminated solely by individual talent. The Soviet Union's dependence on imported American technology was not unnoticed. In his *Glasnost* policies, Gorbachev opened up more industries to foreign trade, especially to increase technology imports from the Western world¹⁹.

The United States' greatest advantage over the USSR lies not in stark scientific superiority, but rather the successful integration of research and innovation with commercialization. In the early 20th century, the Soviet Union produced a great number of scientists who made significant contributions to the theoretical sciences and won Nobel prizes in physics and chemistry. National laboratories were the concentrated centers of resources and scientists, which propelled Soviet science to become one of the world's leaders. The launch of Sputnik and the USSR's prominent position in the space race prove their superiority in the fundamental sciences and heavy industry, but they prove to be unable to respond quickly to the innovation of computers. Furthermore, older officials dominate the national laboratories, obstructing opportunities for young people to engage and lead experiments. Gorbachev recognized the problem with a dominantly elderly, centralized institution, so he enacted limits on the number of senior members in higher positions as a part of his *glasnost* plans²⁰. Meanwhile, the United States took a more decentralized approach to scientific discovery and innovation. Endowments allowed many universities to invest in computer labs with the latest technology, creating a web of communication connected literally by computer wires. Firms were also more responsive to new ideas and innovation, with a production line and established reputations. In turn, successful firms like Apple and Radio Shack provided computers for state schools and

¹⁹ Loren R. Graham, "Gorbachev's Great Experiment," *Issues in Science and Technology* 4, no. 2 (1988): 29, <http://www.jstor.org/stable/43310474>.

²⁰Graham, "Gorbachev's Great," 29..

younger children, exposing the next generation to the newest technology. The two computers mentioned earlier, the Macintosh and the IBM PC, were also the result of US dominance in technological innovation for the past several decades. The first semiconductors were produced in the United States at Nokia's Bell Labs in 1936, starting a long line of American dominance in technology²¹. Labs received adequate funding from firms because their innovation was motivated by real market competition, and the market gave immediate, tangible rewards to bold ideas.

The United States also had an existing consumer base familiar with video games, as the 1980s saw both the rapid expansion and market crash of the arcade industry. One main reason was that Atari, a major gaming console producer, lowered the barriers to entry, leading to a large influx of low-quality, homogeneous games²². Another reason was the rise of personal computers serving a wider range of functions and better computing power, which further plummeted the console market. It was only after Nintendo entered the stage with quality-controlled games that it reignited consumers' interest in arcade and console gaming. *Tetris* was identified early on as the much-coveted game that would bring life to the industry again. During the negotiations, Henk Rogers, a representative sent on behalf of Nintendo America, was sent to secure the *Tetris* license for Nintendo's new handheld, the *Game Boy*. With its small screen and abstract object, *Tetris* was the perfect game to be sold as a game that comes with every Game Boy purchase. Because the United States had an existing market that covered both the upstream (legal license protection, semiconductor manufacturing) and downstream (game retail and gamer base) industries, Nintendo was able to seize the popularity of *Tetris* itself and sell over 35 million²³ copies of *Tetris* with the Game Boy. The game came as a package deal with the Game Boy console; *Tetris*

²¹ "Transistor," in *Britannica Academic*, <https://academic.eb.com/levels/collegiate/article/transistor/73201#236466.toc>.

²² Jiesi Ma, "From the Atari Shock to a Modern Crisis: Analyzing Mass Layoffs in the Post-Pandemic U.S. Video Game Industry," *Games: Research and Practice* 4, no. 1 (2025): 23, <https://doi.org/10.1145/3774758>.

²³ Jonathan Wynne-Jones, "Computer Game Tetris Celebrates 25 Years," *The Telegraph*, accessed June 5, 2009, <https://www.telegraph.co.uk/technology/news/5460283/Computer-game-Tetris-celebrates-25-years.html>.

heralded a new age of gaming with portable handhelds. At the same time, Spectrum Holobyte secured the *Tetris* license for personal computers, marking two of the main platforms for *Tetris* secured by firms in the United States.

The United States also had a complete legal system to ensure the interests of inventors and enact copyright protection. Patent laws in the United States protecting ideas and inventions started as early as the 1790s, and the International Copyright Act of 1891 further extended the protection of copyright to non-United States citizens, as long as the country grants to US citizens copyright protection “substantially the same basis as its own citizens.”²⁴ This protection, enacted nearly a century before the legal disputes of *Tetris*, demonstrates how the United States valued innovation early on and responded quickly to retain and attract talent. On the other hand, the Soviet Union lacked the necessary processes and legislation to protect individual intellectual property. All imported and exported technology was managed by ELORG, a state-owned monopoly, and Pajitov “[hasn’t] received a penny of the profits”, since profits from the game are paid in royalties owned by the state²⁵. In the case of *Tetris*, private corporations in the United States and the United Kingdom were directly negotiating with the government of the Soviet Union. As a stark contrast to the Soviet economic policy of government monopoly over imports and exports, the United States gave more credit to firms and inventors as autonomous legal entities. Spectrum Holobyte, a US-based video game licensing company, was the first to purchase *Tetris* rights from Robert Stein, and the negotiations that followed were conducted solely in the UK and the US. The problem of poor ownership and protection of intellectual

²⁴ International Copyright Act of 1891, 26 Stat.

<https://govtrackus.s3.amazonaws.com/legislink/pdf/stat/26/STATUTE-26-Pg1106.pdf>.

²⁵ PETER GUMBEL Staff Reporter of THE WALL STREET JOURNAL, "Tetris Game Wins Big for Nintendo but Not for Soviet Inventors: They're Left out as Software Falls into Western Hands and Then into Litigation to Russia, a Lesson in Markets," *Wall Street Journal* (1923-) (New York, N.Y.), June 8, 1990, <http://proxy5.noblenet.org/login?url=https://www.proquest.com/newspapers/tetris-game-wins-big-nintendo-not-soviet/docview/135484056/se-2?accountid=13178>.

property is what a senior official of the Computer Center, Vladimir Mazurik, called a “general stupidity” of his country to not “reward people who work hard,”²⁶ as reported by the Wall Street Journal.

Towards the end of the Soviet Union, a sense of cultural curiosity began to slowly undermine the hostility between the two superpowers. When *Tetris* was imported to the United States, Spectro Holobyte heavily marketed its exotic elements both on the packaging and in the cutscenes of the game. The game came with a bright red box, bold yellow Cyrillic alphabet, and the sickle & hammer as the “S” in “Tetris”. In the MS-DOS version published by Spectrum Holobyte, the game boot-up screen featured the Kremlin, the slogan “Play Tetris!” written out in Russian, and the game itself featured various winter landscapes and landmarks of Soviet Russia²⁷. One version of Tetris published by Amiga Entertainment claims “The Cold War is over...Almost” on its advertisement poster.²⁸ The military competition between the nations cooled down to a fear that stayed in the past. The diplomatic relationship between the Soviet Union and the United States also softened towards the dissolution of the USSR. Gorbachev needed to divert government budget from military spending to bolster the economic revival of his country, and now he had similar interests with the United States. After several successful negotiations with the United States to eliminate missiles, Gorbachev removed Soviet troops from Afghanistan in 1988, the same year Reagan visited Moscow.²⁹ Though the Cold War only ended officially in 1991, the tension greatly escalated between them, and, finally, there was a prospect of peaceful coexistence.

²⁶PETER GUMBEL Staff Reporter of THE WALL STREET JOURNAL, "Tetris Game".

²⁷ Alexey Pajitov, *MS-DOS Tetris*, Internet Archive, 1988, https://archive.org/details/TETRIS_PCJR.

²⁸ Drew Robarge, "Tetris: Fun in the Cold War?," National Museum of American History, last modified November 6, 2014, accessed April 2, 2026, <https://americanhistory.si.edu/explore/stories/tetris-fun-cold-war>.

²⁹ Eric Foner et al., *Give Me Liberty!: An American History*, 7th ed. (W. W. Norton & Company, 2023), 843.

Tetris was born in a coincidental time of the Cold War. Had Gorbachev come into power later, *Tetris* might have already been forgotten as yet another viral trend that happened briefly within the academy. In the modern day, Pajitov and Rogers are joined by their collective passion for gaming and created the *Tetris* company, a sole authority for distributing all *Tetris* licenses. The inventor received what he deserved, while the entrepreneur also stayed true to his promises and gave appropriate credit to Pajitov. Looking back in history, *Tetris* reached world renown today as a combined effort of Soviet ingenuity, American entrepreneurship, and alleviation of Cold War tensions- tetromino pieces that happened to fall in the right way to create a global sensation.

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